THE HARAPPAN CIVILIZATION

HARAPPAN CHRONOLOGY: REGIONAL ROOTS → HARAPPAN SPATIAL SYSTEM AND → URBAN-RURAL SETTLEMENT HIERARCHY → BUILT ORDER, WATER AND → THE HARAPPAN ECONOMY AS → INTERNAL AND OVERSEAS EXCHANGE

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure: the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

◆ PRIMARY CORE FLOW ◆ SUBORDINATE EXTRA ◆ APPROVAL / REVIEW

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • source generation g14 and all prior artifacts unchanged

00

STAGE 00

HARAPPAN CHRONOLOGY: REGIONAL ROOTS TO LOCALISATION

HARAPPAN CHRONOLOGY | REGIONAL ROOTS TO LOCALISATION | LATE/LOCALISATION C. 3300-2600 BCE C. 2600-1900 BCE C. 1900-1300 | INTEGRATED URBAN-RURAL NETWORK; DECLINE | REGIONAL TRANSFORMATION.

EARLY/REGIONALISATION → MATURE/INTEGRATION → LATE/LOCALISATION c. → 3300-2600 BCE c. → 2600-1900 BCE c. → 1900-1300 BCE regional towns/crafts shared weights, seals, de-urbanisation, local ceramics, and exchange networks script, urban → Civilisation = integrated urban-rural network; decline = regional transformation.

CHRONOLOGY / PHASE

- EARLY/REGIONALISATION → MATURE/INTEGRATION → LATE/LOCALISATION c.
- 3300-2600 BCE c.

MATERIAL / INSTITUTION

- 2600-1900 BCE c.
- 1900-1300 BCE regional towns/crafts shared weights, seals, de-urbanisation, local ceramics, and exchange networks script, urban systems settlement shifts,

IMPACT / LIMIT

- Civilisation = integrated urban-rural network; decline = regional transformation.
- EARLY/REGIONALISATION → MATURE/INTEGRATION → LATE/LOCALISATION c.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Civilisation = integrated urban-rural network; decline = regional transformation.

01

STAGE 01

HARAPPAN SPATIAL SYSTEM AND SITE ATLAS

HARAPPAN SPATIAL SYSTEM AND SITE ATLAS | MAKRAN EDGE | JAMMU FRONTIER | CORE INDUS | URBAN/CEMETERY SEQUENCE | GREAT BATH/DRAINS | PLOUGHED FIELD/FIRE INSTALLATIONS | FORTIFIED TOWN

WEST: Sutkagendor → Makran edge

NORTH: Manda → Jammu frontier → CORE INDUS: Harappa → urban/cemetery sequence → Mohenjo-daro → Great Bath/drains

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- WEST: Sutkagendor → Makran edge
- NORTH: Manda → Jammu frontier
- CORE INDUS: Harappa → urban/cemetery sequence
- Mohenjo-daro → Great Bath/drains
- GHAGGAR: Kalibangan → ploughed field/fire installations

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- Banawali → fortified town
- EAST: Rakhigarhi → major Haryana complex
- Alamgirpur → eastern Late Harappan edge
- KUTCH: Dholavira → three-part city, reservoirs, signboard
- Surkotada → fortification

DEBATE / LEGACY

- GUJARAT: Lothal → basin/warehouse/craft debate
- Rangpur → regional sequence
- SINDH: Chanhudaro → craft centre; no classic citadel-lower-town profile

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: SINDH: Chanhudaro → craft centre; no classic citadel-lower-town profile.

02

STAGE 02

URBAN-RURAL SETTLEMENT HIERARCHY

URBAN-RURAL SETTLEMENT HIERARCHY | FARM/PASTORAL HAMLETS | CRAFT/ROUTE CENTRES | REGIONAL CITIES FOOD AND HERDS STORAGE SPECIALISED OUTPUT COORDINATION/CONSUMPTION | URBANISM DEPENDED ON RURAL SURPLUS AND RAW-MATERIAL CORRIDORS; CITIES

FARM/PASTORAL HAMLETS → VILLAGES → CRAFT/ROUTE CENTRES → REGIONAL CITIES food and herds storage specialised

output coordination/consumption weights + seals + transport + shared styles connect unequal regional domains. → Urbanism depended on rural surplus and raw-material corridors; cities were not isolated.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- FARM/PASTORAL HAMLETS → VILLAGES → CRAFT/ROUTE CENTRES → REGIONAL CITIES food and herds storage specialised
- output coordination/consumption weights + seals + transport + shared styles connect unequal regional domains.

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- Urbanism depended on rural surplus and raw-material corridors; cities were not isolated.
- FARM/PASTORAL HAMLETS → VILLAGES → CRAFT/ROUTE CENTRES → REGIONAL CITIES food and herds storage specialised

DEBATE / LEGACY

- output coordination/consumption weights + seals + transport + shared styles connect unequal regional domains.
- Urbanism depended on rural surplus and raw-material corridors; cities were not isolated.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Urbanism depended on rural surplus and raw-material corridors; cities were not isolated.

03

STAGE 03

BUILT ORDER, WATER AND CIVIC MAINTENANCE

BUILT ORDER, WATER AND CIVIC MAINTENANCE | PLANNED STREETS + STANDARD BRICKS + PLATFORMS + COURTYARD | BATHING AREAS | COVERED DRAINS | SOAK PITS/INSPECTION ACCESS HOUSEHOLD INVESTMENT COLLECTIVE MAINTENANCE | DHOLAVIRA ADAPTS RESERVOIRS TO ARIDITY; MOHENJO-DARO STRESSES WELLS AND

PLANNED STREETS + STANDARD BRICKS + PLATFORMS + COURTYARD HOUSES wells/reservoirs → bathing → areas → covered drains → soak pits/inspection access household investment collective maintenance → Dholavira adapts reservoirs to aridity; Mohenjo-daro stresses wells and drains.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- PLANNED STREETS + STANDARD BRICKS + PLATFORMS + COURTYARD HOUSES wells/reservoirs → bathing
- areas → covered drains → soak pits/inspection access household investment collective maintenance

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- Dholavira adapts reservoirs to aridity; Mohenjo-daro stresses wells and drains.
- PLANNED STREETS + STANDARD BRICKS + PLATFORMS + COURTYARD HOUSES wells/reservoirs → bathing

DEBATE / LEGACY

- areas → covered drains → soak pits/inspection access household investment collective maintenance
- Dholavira adapts reservoirs to aridity; Mohenjo-daro stresses wells and drains.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Dholavira adapts reservoirs to aridity; Mohenjo-daro stresses wells and drains.

04

STAGE 04

THE HARAPPAN ECONOMY AS A LINKED SYSTEM

THE HARAPPAN ECONOMY AS A LINKED SYSTEM | AGRICULTURAL-PASTORAL BASE WHEAT/BARLEY CATTLE COTTON FISHING/REGIONAL CROPS | CRAFT WORKSHOPS | CALIBRATED WEIGHTS | BEADS, SHELL, FAIENCE, POTTERY, COPPER/BRONZE; STONE REMAINS IMPORTANT.

AGRICULTURAL-PASTORAL BASE wheat/barley cattle cotton fishing/regional crops

SURPLUS → craft workshops → calibrated weights → seals/transport → exchange → CRAFTS: beads, shell, faience, pottery, copper/bronze; stone remains important.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- AGRICULTURAL-PASTORAL BASE wheat/barley cattle cotton fishing/regional crops
- SURPLUS → craft workshops → calibrated weights → seals/transport → exchange

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- CRAFTS: beads, shell, faience, pottery, copper/bronze; stone remains important.
- AGRICULTURAL-PASTORAL BASE wheat/barley cattle cotton fishing/regional crops

DEBATE / LEGACY

- SURPLUS → craft workshops → calibrated weights → seals/transport → exchange
- CRAFTS: beads, shell, faience, pottery, copper/bronze; stone remains important.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CRAFTS: beads, shell, faience, pottery, copper/bronze; stone remains important.

05

STAGE 05

INTERNAL AND OVERSEAS EXCHANGE CORRIDORS

INTERNAL AND OVERSEAS EXCHANGE CORRIDORS | RAW MATERIAL FLOW | INDUS CITIES | COPPER CORRIDOR | PRODUCTION ZONES | SHELL, CARNELIAN, COASTAL ROUTES | CRAFTS AND PORTS | MESOPOTAMIA: MELUHHA IN CUNEIFORM TEXTS.

RAW MATERIAL FLOW

Baluchistan/Afghanistan → metals/stones → Indus cities → Rajasthan/Khetri → copper corridor → production zones → Gujarat/Kutch → shell, carnelian, coastal routes → crafts and ports

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- RAW MATERIAL FLOW
- Baluchistan/Afghanistan → metals/stones → Indus cities
- Rajasthan/Khetri → copper corridor → production zones

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- Gujarat/Kutch → shell, carnelian, coastal routes → crafts and ports
- Indus/Makran/Gulf → Dilmun/Magan → Mesopotamia: Meluhha in cuneiform texts
- Trade evidence = imports + texts + seals + production; it does not prove colonies.

DEBATE / LEGACY

- Lothal basin has dockyard/reservoir interpretations; state the debate.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Lothal basin has dockyard/reservoir interpretations: state the debate.

06

STAGE 06

SOCIETY AND POLITY: EVIDENCE WITHOUT INVENTED KINGS

SOCIETY AND POLITY | EVIDENCE WITHOUT INVENTED KINGS | HOUSE VARIATION + SCARCE GOODS + CRAFT CONTROL + | NO SECURE PALACE, ROYAL TOMB OR DECIPHERED KING-LIST; HIERARCHY | COORDINATED INSTITUTIONS ARE CERTAIN: EMPIRE-LEVEL SOVEREIGNTY IS UNPROVEN.

SOURCE / MATERIAL

- EVIDENCE: house variation + scarce goods + craft control + standards + public works centralised state?
- city/regional states?

METHOD / DEBATE

- corporate or mercantile elites?
- NO secure palace, royal tomb or deciphered king-list; hierarchy existed, form is open.

HISTORICAL RESULT

- VERDICT: coordinated institutions are certain; empire-level sovereignty is unproven.
- EVIDENCE: house variation + scarce goods + craft control + standards + public works centralised state?

MECHANISM / VERDICT — VERDICT: coordinated institutions are certain; empire-level sovereignty is unproven.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: coordinated institutions are certain; empire-level sovereignty is unproven.

07

STAGE 07

SCRIPT, SEALS AND RELIGION: EVIDENCE LADDER

SCRIPT, SEALS AND RELIGION | EVIDENCE LADDER | SHORT SIGNS, SEALS/TABLETS, MOTIFS, RITUAL INSTALLATIONS, BURIALS, FIGURINES | IDENTITY/TRANSACTION MARKING AND DIFFERENTIATED RITUAL PRACTICES | SCRIPT LANGUAGE; PROTO-SHIVA; MOTHER-GODDESS SYSTEM; UNIVERSAL FIRE ALTARS | READING LATER HINDU DOCTRINE DIRECTLY INTO EVERY HARAPPAN IMAGE. | UNDECIPHERED SCRIPT BLOCKS DIRECT ACCESS TO OFFICE, BELIEF AND | USE OBJECT + CONTEXT + DISTRIBUTION BEFORE ANALOGY.

SOURCE / MATERIAL

- SECURE: short signs, seals/tablets, motifs, ritual installations, burials, figurines
- PROBABLE: identity/transaction marking and differentiated ritual practices

METHOD / DEBATE

- DISPUTED: script language; proto-Shiva; mother-goddess system; universal fire altars
- REJECT: reading later Hindu doctrine directly into every Harappan image.

HISTORICAL RESULT

- Undeciphered script blocks direct access to office, belief and political vocabulary.
- Use object + context + distribution before analogy.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Use object + context + distribution before analogy.

08

STAGE 08

DE-URBANISATION: INTERACTING REGIONAL CAUSES

INTERACTING REGIONAL CAUSES | RIVER SHIFTS/FLOODS + ARIDIFICATION + EXCHANGE CONTRACTION + MAINTENANCE | CITY CONTRACTION/ABANDONMENT | SETTLEMENT REDISTRIBUTION LOSS | SCRIPT, SEALS, LARGE CITIES CONTINUITY | CROPS, CRAFTS, VILLAGES | NO INVASION OR SINGLE RIVER EXPLAINS ALL REGIONS; TIMINGS

river shifts/floods + aridification + exchange contraction + maintenance stress weaker standards → city

contraction/abandonment → settlement redistribution loss: script, seals, large cities continuity: crops, crafts, villages → No invasion or single river explains all regions; timings and outcomes differ.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- river shifts/floods + aridification + exchange contraction + maintenance stress weaker standards → city
- contraction/abandonment → settlement redistribution loss: script, seals, large cities continuity: crops, crafts, villages

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- No invasion or single river explains all regions; timings and outcomes differ.
- river shifts/floods + aridification + exchange contraction + maintenance stress weaker standards → city

DEBATE / LEGACY

- contraction/abandonment → settlement redistribution loss: script, seals, large cities continuity: crops, crafts, villages
- No invasion or single river explains all regions; timings and outcomes differ.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: No invasion or single river explains all regions; timings and outcomes differ.

09

STAGE 09

HARAPPAN ANSWER ARCHITECTURE: 10/15/20 MARKS

HARAPPAN ANSWER ARCHITECTURE | 10/15/20 MARKS | 10 MARKS | SITE-FEATURE TRIAD | INTERPRETATION CAUTION | 15 MARKS | SPATIAL SYSTEM | URBAN FORM

10 MARKS: phase → site-feature triad → mechanism → interpretation caution → 15 MARKS: chronology → spatial system → urban form → economy → polity/religion limits → 20 MARKS: integration → site map → urban-rural economy → water/standards/trade → society-polity evidence → script/ritual limits → transformation → BENCHMARK: material uniformity indicates integration, not automatic political unity.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- 10 MARKS: phase → site-feature triad → mechanism → interpretation caution
- 15 MARKS: chronology → spatial system → urban form → economy → polity/religion limits

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- 20 MARKS: integration → site map → urban-rural economy → water/standards/trade
- society-polity evidence → script/ritual limits → transformation

DEBATE / LEGACY

- BENCHMARK: material uniformity indicates integration, not automatic political unity.
- CLOSE: a varied civilisation coordinated by standards, exchange and maintenance.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CLOSE: a varied civilisation coordinated by standards, exchange and maintenance.

10

STAGE 10

EVIDENCE LADDER AND CONFIDENCE CONTROL

EVIDENCE LADDER AND CONFIDENCE CONTROL | EVIDENCE LADDER | FROM SOURCE BOOK | STANDARD KNOWLEDGE | CURRENT AFFAIRS. | 2. SITE LOCATION | RIVER SIGNATURE FIND | 3. SPINDLE WHORLS ARE COMMON CRAFT EVIDENCE; SHELL/IVORY SCALES

SOURCE / MATERIAL	METHOD / DEBATE	HISTORICAL RESULT
EVIDENCE LADDER	2. Site Location / river Signature find	VERDICT: Source type controls the strength and limits of the historical claim.
1. = from source book + inference / standard knowledge + current affairs.	3. Spindle whorls are common craft evidence; shell/ivory scales and...	EVIDENCE LADDER

SOURCE / MATERIAL

- EVIDENCE LADDER
- 1. = from source book + inference / standard knowledge + current affairs.

METHOD / DEBATE

- 2. Site Location / river Signature find
- 3. Spindle whorls are common craft evidence: shell/ivory scales and...

HISTORICAL RESULT

- VERDICT: Source type controls the strength and limits of the historical claim.
- EVIDENCE LADDER

MECHANISM / VERDICT — VERDICT: Source type controls the strength and limits of the historical claim.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Source type controls the strength and limits of the historical claim.

11

STAGE 11

EXAMINER TRAPS AND CONTESTED BOUNDARIES

EXAMINER TRAPS AND CONTESTED BOUNDARIES | CLOSE DISTINCTIONS | 1. EVIDENCE DISCIPLINE | CONTESTED CHRONOLOGY AND INTERPRETATION REMAIN | 2. CONTESTED ISSUES COMPETING INTERPRETATIONS ARE ATTRIBUTED, EVIDENCED | 3. INSCRIPTION AND COIN EVIDENCE | CONTEMPORARY NAMES, TITLES, CLAIMS AND | QUALIFICATION EARNS MARKS; FALSE CERTAINTY IS A HARD FAILURE.

CLOSE DISTINCTIONS → 1. Evidence discipline: contested chronology and interpretation remain → 2. Contested issues Competing interpretations are attributed, evidenced → 3. Inscription and coin evidence: contemporary names, titles, claims and → VERDICT: Qualification earns marks; false certainty is a hard failure.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- CLOSE DISTINCTIONS
- 1. Evidence discipline: contested chronology and interpretation remain...

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- 2. Contested issues Competing interpretations are attributed, evidenced...
- 3. Inscription and coin evidence: contemporary names, titles, claims and...

DEBATE / LEGACY

- VERDICT: Qualification earns marks; false certainty is a hard failure.
- CLOSE DISTINCTIONS

MECHANISM / VERDICT — VERDICT: Qualification earns marks; false certainty is a hard failure.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Qualification earns marks; false certainty is a hard failure.

E

EXTRA

SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT | 1. SNAPSHOT & CORE IDEA | 2. DEBATES & INTERPRETATIONS (HIGH-YIELD TABLE) | GENETICS AND HARAPPAN/VEDIC QUESTIONS — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED] | 3. STUDY LINKS | 4. MUST-KNOW FACTS (PRELIMS) | + EXACT PYQ APPLICATION (2025 GS-I) | 5. UPSC TRAPS

OPTIONAL SOURCE DEPTH

- Mini-timeline
- 1. Snapshot & core idea
- 2. Debates & interpretations (high-yield table)
- Genetics and Harappan/Vedic Questions — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]

ADVANCED DEBATE

- 3. Study links
- 4. Must-Know Facts (Prelims)
- + Exact PYQ application (2025 GS-I)
- 5. UPSC Traps

LEGACY / NUANCE

- 7. Mains angles
- Optional Advanced Studios: Distinct Refinements — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]
- A1. Urbanism, Households and Craft — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]
- A2. Standardisation and Authority — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.

END OF MASTER CANVAS • poster embeds this exact master • tiled pages are overlapping crops of the same pixels